



Art History and Criticism 1 Honors

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · COURSE SYLLABUS · 2026–
2027

Full Year · Grades 9–12 · Honors

Teacher

Optima Academy Online Faculty

FLORIDA COURSE

Florida 0100330 · Honors · 1 credit · Full-year course

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 9–12 (High School) ·

Performing/Fine Arts graduation credit

EMAIL & OFFICE

Your teacher's email is posted in Canvas · 239.673.2801
(OAO Front Office)

OFFICE HOURS

Posted in Canvas · weekly study hall and virtual museum visits

FORMAT

On-Demand (also offered live on the VR campus)

About this syllabus. This is the plan for the course as designed. It is a full-year, honors-level high school course; On-Demand scholars pace through the eleven units and two culminating projects across the four quarters of their enrolled year. On-Demand and live-school sections share the same content and expectations; exact pacing, scheduled dates, and a few activities may vary from section to section and term to term. Your teacher will confirm the specifics for your section.

COURSE OVERVIEW

Art History and Criticism 1 Honors introduces scholars to significant works of art and architecture from Prehistory through Contemporary Art. Through careful observation and analysis of paintings, sculpture, and architecture, scholars explore how artists across cultures and centuries expressed ideas, beliefs, values, and beauty. The course teaches a four-step method of art criticism (describe, analyze, interpret, judge) in Unit 1 and applies it to real masterworks in every unit that follows: the caves of Lascaux, the Palette of Narmer, the Parthenon, the Colosseum, Hagia Sophia, the Mona Lisa, Caravaggio, the Impressionists, and the modern and contemporary movements. Each unit pairs interactive lessons with a written analysis, a comparison discussion, a hands-on creation activity inspired by the period, and a quiz. Two culminating projects anchor the year: a Virtual Museum Exhibit that scholars curate at the end of Semester 1, and an Art Historian Portfolio that gathers their strongest work at the end of the year.

WHAT SCHOLARS WILL LEARN TO DO

- Analyze and interpret significant works of art and architecture.
- Compare artistic traditions across cultures and time periods.
- Examine the historical and cultural contexts of artistic production.
- Apply art criticism methods to historical and contemporary artworks.
- Develop vocabulary for discussing art, architecture, and visual culture.
- Engage in creative activities inspired by historical artistic traditions.

- Find, evaluate, and cite sources with academic integrity.
- Build an appreciation for the role of art in human history.

COURSE OUTLINE

UNIT	TIME	WRITTEN ANALYSIS
Semester 1 · Foundations Through Medieval Art		
1 · Introduction to Art History & Criticism	2 weeks	Formal Analysis of a Selected Artwork
2 · Prehistoric Art	2 weeks	Lascaux Cave Painting Analysis
3 · Ancient Egypt & Mesopotamia	3 weeks	Palette of Narmer Analysis
4 · Ancient Greece	3 weeks	Parthenon Analysis
5 · Ancient Rome	2–3 weeks	Augustus of Prima Porta or Colosseum Analysis
6 · Byzantine, Islamic & Medieval Art	3 weeks	Hagia Sophia or Gothic Cathedral Analysis
Semester 1 Culminating Project: Virtual Museum Exhibit	2 weeks	Curated digital exhibit (5–7 works)
Semester 2 · Renaissance Through Contemporary Art		
7 · Renaissance Art	3 weeks	Formal Analysis of a Renaissance Masterpiece
8 · Baroque & Rococo	2–3 weeks	Calling of St. Matthew or Ecstasy of St. Teresa Analysis
9 · Neoclassicism, Romanticism & Realism	3 weeks	The Stone Breakers Analysis
10 · Impressionism & Post-Impressionism	2 weeks	Impressionist Artwork Analysis
11 · Modern & Contemporary Art	3 weeks	Student-Selected Modern or Contemporary Artwork Analysis
Semester 2 Culminating Project: Art Historian Portfolio	2 weeks	Compiled portfolio + final reflection

BIG PROJECTS & MILESTONES

The course builds toward two finished, real-world artifacts. Target dates below follow a sample full-year pacing; On-Demand scholars pace to their own enrolled term and Live sections follow the class schedule, keeping each milestone roughly in order.

PROJECT / MILESTONE	COURSE PLACE	SAMPLE TARGET	WHAT YOU TURN IN
---------------------	--------------	---------------	------------------

Virtual Museum Exhibit	End of Semester 1	by Dec 18 (Q2)	A curated PowerPoint exhibit of 5–7 works from Units 1–6, organized around your own theme, with museum labels you write using the four-step method, cited sources, and an optional VR gallery walkthrough.
Art Historian Portfolio (course final)	End of Semester 2	by May 21 (Q4)	A compiled Word portfolio of your strongest analyses, comparisons, and creations from the whole year, with a table of contents and a final reflective essay tracing how your eye and judgment grew.

IMPORTANT DATES — 2026–2027

Aug 12, 2026	First day of school
Sep 7	Holiday (Labor Day)
Oct 9	Quarter 1 ends
Oct 12	Holiday (Columbus Day)
Nov 11	Holiday (Veterans' Day)
Nov 23–27	Thanksgiving break
Dec 18	Quarter 2 ends · fall semester ends
Dec 21–Jan 1	Winter break
Jan 5, 2027	Classes resume
Jan 18	Holiday (MLK Day)
Feb 15	Holiday (Presidents' Day)
Mar 5	Quarter 3 ends
Mar 26–Apr 5	Spring break
Apr 6	Classes resume
May 28, 2027	Quarter 4 ends · last day of school
May 31	Holiday (Memorial Day)

ASSESSMENT & GRADING

60% Major projects & assessments (unit analyses and the two culminating projects)	30% Assignments, quizzes & creative activities	10% Reflections, discussions & participation
---	--	--

Throughout the course, scholars demonstrate learning through artwork analyses, comparison discussions, historical interpretation activities, quizzes, virtual museum journals, creative projects, reflections, and the two semester culminating projects.

HOW THIS COURSE IS DELIVERED

This course is offered in two formats that share the same content, assignments, and expectations: an **On-Demand (asynchronous)** section you pace yourself, and a **Live (synchronous)** section that meets on a schedule on Optima's VR campus. The two overviews below explain how each one works. Find the one that matches your enrollment.

ON-DEMAND (ASYNCHRONOUS) LEARNING

In the **On-Demand** section you move through the course at your own pace within each quarter, guided by due dates that keep you on track. All assignments for a quarter open at its start and close at its end. Because the course is On-Demand, there is no grade penalty for missing an individual due date, but any assignment not completed by the end of the quarter receives a **zero**, and assignments submitted in the final **14 days** of a quarter receive a **10% deduction**, so steady pacing matters.

Attendance is measured by assignment completion. Per school policy, a scholar who completes no assignment for ten consecutive school days, without notifying the school of an absence in advance, may be dropped from the course. Completion means a **sincere attempt**: real effort on real work. Rushed work, wrong or corrupted files, irrelevant or nonsense submissions, AI-generated filler, and word-salad responses do not count.

You are never on your own. A live teacher grades your work, gives feedback, and hosts a weekly study hall and virtual museum visits.

LIVE (SYNCHRONOUS) LEARNING

In the **Live** section you join scheduled class meetings on Optima's VR campus, where your teacher leads instruction in real time and you learn alongside classmates. The readings, assignments, and projects are the same as the On-Demand course; what differs is the pacing. A Live section moves through the material together on the class schedule rather than at each scholar's own pace, and class time is also used for discussion, guided looking at artworks, and critique practice.

Attendance is measured by presence and participation. You are expected to attend the scheduled live sessions, on time and ready to take part. If you must miss a class, notify the school in advance; your teacher will let you know how to make up the work and any material you missed. As in every Optima course, completing your work means a sincere attempt, and assignments still open and close with each quarter.

You meet regularly with a teacher. The class gathers throughout the week in VR and on Microsoft Teams for live instruction and discussion.

APPROPRIATE USE OF AI

Optima scholars are preparing for a world shaped by artificial intelligence, and learning to use these tools with good judgment is part of that preparation. You are welcome to use AI tools to **support** your learning, such as explaining a concept a different way, checking your understanding, or brainstorming, unless a particular assignment says otherwise. What AI may **never** do is the thinking or the work an assignment asks of you: an analysis, a reflection, a discussion post, or a creative project must be genuinely your own. In this course especially, the graded analyses measure *your own eye*: AI tools often invent details that are not in the artwork and cannot verify claims against the actual image. Submitting AI-generated text as if it were your own work is dishonest and counts as an insincere attempt. When you do use an AI tool on an assignment, say so briefly. Above all, build the underlying skill yourself; the goal is for you to be able to judge whether an AI's answer is any good, which you can only do if you can do the work without it.

LEARNING IN VIRTUAL REALITY

Optima is a virtual-reality school. Alongside your Canvas coursework, this course includes virtual museum experiences: a Museum Journal in Unit 2, an Architecture Journal in Unit 5, and optional VR galleries for both culminating projects. Keep your headset charged and ready for any scheduled VR sessions, and treat the VR campus with the same courtesy and seriousness you would a physical one. If you ever cannot get into VR for a session, tell your teacher; there is an alternative way to take part so you do not fall behind.

BEING AN OPTIMA SCHOLAR

Optima's mission is an excellent, virtue-centered education, and virtue is at the center of this course as much as any other. Every scholar is expected to practice the seven virtues that shape life at Optima: **courage, courtesy, honesty, perseverance, self-government, service, and responsibility**. In this course that especially means honesty about what the evidence in an artwork does and does not show, perseverance in slow, careful looking, and courtesy toward classmates and toward the cultures and traditions whose art you study. Do your own honest work; treat everyone you meet in, through, or because of this course with respect; engage actively rather than passively; come to office hours; and take responsibility for your own pacing and progress. You belong to a house and a community of scholars, not only to a course.

WHAT YOU NEED & STAYING CONNECTED

- ✓ A computer with reliable internet and access to **Canvas**.
- ✓ A **VR headset**, charged and ready, for the virtual museum experiences.
- ✓ **Microsoft 365** (Word, PowerPoint) with OneDrive, for the analyses and projects you create and submit.
- ✓ A **sketchbook or plain paper**, plus pencils and simple color media (colored pencils, markers, or paint you have on hand), for the hands-on creation activities.

- ✔ A phone or camera to photograph your creation activities for submission.

Staying connected. Updates about this course are posted on the course's Canvas page; school-wide updates are posted in your Homeroom Canvas course. Check both regularly. Your teacher holds office hours and is glad to help with the material, to meet you, or to talk through your plans. Come by, or reach out any time by email.

Art History and Criticism 1 Honors · Florida course 0100330 · Full-year honors high school course · Performing/Fine Arts graduation credit · Optima Academy Online, 2026–2027. Built from the course content (11 units + 2 culminating projects) and the board-approved 2026–2027 academic calendar. Project target dates reflect a sample full-year pacing; On-Demand scholars pace to their own enrolled term. School calendar dates may be adjusted by the school.

Course materials & copyright. Optima Academy Online course materials are original instructional materials. Artworks are reproduced only where in the public domain or used as a limited fair-use excerpt for educational analysis, with sources cited; works under copyright are linked to the holding institution rather than reproduced.